

The Unified Path

A Visual Guide to Samadhi, Jhana, and Liberation

Distilled frameworks from the teachings of Richard Shankman.

The Integration Funnel

The diagram illustrates 'The Integration Funnel' as a conceptual model for Buddhist practice. It features two streams of light, one blue and one gold, flowing downwards from the top corners towards a central point. These streams converge into a single, bright white beam that extends downwards. The background is a dark, textured blue. The entire diagram is framed by a thin white border.

Stream 1: Concentration (Samatha)

Focus: Serenity, calm, and undistractedness.

Effect: Empties the mind of agitation; fills the mind with wholesome presence and joy.

Stream 2: Insight (Vipassana)

The Three perities tailht mind.

Focus: Seeing clearly the nature of reality to end suffering.

The Three Characteristics:

1. Anicca (Impermanence / Moment-to-moment change)
2. Dukkha (Unreliability / Unsatisfactoriness)
3. Anatta (No permanent, eternal soul/essence)

The Convergence Core

As Samadhi deepens, perception acts like an 'electron microscope.' The mind does not disconnect; rather, the absolute stillness naturally enhances the direct perception of Insight. It is a single unified path of cultivation.

Defining Samadhi: Two Kinds of Stopping



Exclusive Samadhi (One-Pointedness)

- **Focus:** Narrowly restricted to one object (e.g., the breath).
- **Body Awareness:** Lost. The meditator no longer feels the physical body.
- **Experience:** The changing flow of experience comes to a complete stop. Other brain centers quiet down.
- **Direction:** Disconnecting / purely mental.



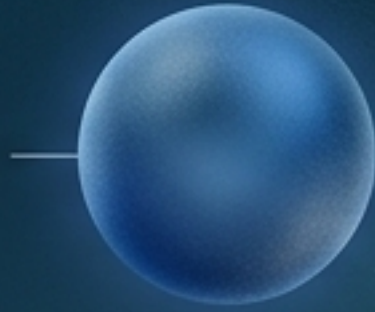
Inclusive Samadhi (Unification of Mind)

- **Focus:** Broad, open, and inclusive of all arising phenomena.
- **Body Awareness:** Retained and deeply enhanced.
- **Experience:** The mind itself comes to a steady, unmoving stop, but the flow of experience continues.
- **Direction:** Connecting / integrating.

Note: This deck maps the path of Inclusive Samadhi.

The Object Merger Model

The Breath
The anchor. Can be felt at the nose, belly, chest, or as "whole body breathing".



Piti (Pleasantness)
The physical/mental manifestation of deepening calm. Experienced as energy, vibration, lightness, or profound stillness.



The Shift: Do not force this. If drawn to the Piti, test making the pleasantness the primary object. If agitated, return to the breath.



The Samadhi Breath
The ultimate unified object. The sensation of breathing and the blissful energy of Piti blend into a single, seamless experience. The mind naturally rests here, leading to Whole Body Samadhi.

Right Effort: Navigating the Balance

Over-Efforting (Tension)

- Symptoms: Feeling tight, tense, overworked, or exhausted.
- Adjustment: Back off. Samadhi does the work for you as it deepens.



The "Lighter Touch"

The perfect balance between intending and relaxing. As concentration builds, effort transforms from active 'doing' to a state of being naturally 'drawn in' by the pleasantness of Samadhi. It is a feeling of giving yourself over, much like allowing sleep to take you.

Over-Letting Go (Spacing Out)

- Symptoms: Lifting out of the meditation, mind wandering, losing connection.
- Adjustment: Up the intention. Bring back a sense of doing or active efforting.

The Insight Shift: Working With Difficulty

Context: Difficulties are not obstacles; they are the present moment teaching the mind how to let go of clinging. Do not struggle against them.

Step 1: Mindfulness OF Breathing (Foreground Object)

Action: The breath remains the primary focus. The physical pain or mental agitation is allowed to simply exist in the background without resistance.



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Action: The breath remains the primary focus. The physical pain or mental agitation without resistance.

If difficulty becomes too strong...

Step 2: Mindfulness WITH Breathing (Shared Foreground)

Action: Allow the breath to meet the experience. Breathe acts as a stabilizing anchor to safely meet the difficulty.

If experience demands full attention...

Step 3: Full Mindfulness of the Difficulty (Shift to Insight)

Action: Drop the breath entirely. Give full, non-reactive awareness to the difficulty to truly meet the difficulty.



Step 3: Full Mindfulness of the Difficulty (Shift to Insight)

Action: Drop the breath entirely. Give full, non-reactive awareness to the difficulty until it subsides. Once the mind can concentrate again, seamlessly return to Step 1.

Cycles of Purification



The Threshold: Entering Jhana



Core Teaching: You Cannot Force Jhana

The deeper stages of Samadhi are not stages of gaining or attaining. They are profound states of letting go.

If you hold a glass of water in your hand, no matter how much you try, you will never bring it to complete stillness. But if you set the glass down and let go, on its own it will settle out and come to stillness.

The Three Pillars of Jhana

Ekaggata (Unification): The mind is unmoving, incredibly steady, and will not wander off.

Self-Sustaining: The meditator does nothing to maintain it; the state sustains itself entirely on its own.

Heightened Perception: Awareness acts like an 'electron microscope' (finely attuned) or a 'space telescope' (vastly expansive).

The Four Jhanas: A Process of Simplification

First Jhana



Active Factors

Vitakka/Vichara (Thought/Examination), Piti (Rapture), Sukha (Pleasure), Ekaggata (Unification).

Simile

The Bathman

Kneading soap powder with water until the entire ball is perfectly steeped and pervaded.



Second Jhana



Factor Dropped

Thought and examination still completely.

Simile

The Spring Lake

Cool waters welling up silently from deep within a lake, permeating it without external movement.



Third Jhana



Factor Dropped

Piti (Rapture) fades away, leaving only Sukha and Equanimity.

Simile

The Submerged Lotus

A flower living its entire life cycle entirely immersed in cool water, requiring no action to be saturated.



Fourth Jhana



Factor Dropped

Sukha (Pleasure/Pain) is abandoned. Only pure, bright mind and equanimity remain.

Simile

The White Cloth

A person covered head-to-toe in a pristine white cloth, pervaded by pure, luminous awareness.



Navigating Jhana: Two Natural Tendencies



The Investigators

- **Action:** Directing the attention.
- **Experience:** Naturally noticing how directing the mind affects perception. Bringing in active discernment to notice subtle details, mechanisms, and shifts within the Jhana state.

The Marinators

- **Action:** Doing absolutely nothing.
- **Experience:** Resting entirely in the state of Jhana. Allowing the meditative state to naturally unfold and reveal itself without actively probing or dissecting it.

Moving Through Jhana

Progression through the stages happens in two distinct ways, regardless of practitioner type:

1. Letting go of grosser levels (e.g., intentionally dropping the strong energetic vibration of Piti for the profound quiet of Sukha).
2. Leaning into subtler levels (gently feeling into the deepening stillness and allowing the mind to be drawn further in).

Beyond Form: The Formless Attainments Topology



The Horizons of Samadhi



The Abhinnaas (Higher Knowledges)

Traditional psychic phenomena (e.g., reading minds) and supernormal powers (the Iddhis).

Acknowledged in ancient texts, though exceptionally rare in practice.



Unconventional Manifestations

Experiences outside traditional Buddhist frameworks that still hold liberating value: shafts of divine light, encounters with angelic realms, or a profound merging into oneness with life.



Cessation & The Deathless

Cessation: The total ending of “becoming” (overlaying our views on experience).

The Deathless: Not a “thing,” and not “nothing.” Pure eternity beyond time and space. The complete dissolution of the self into the unmanifest, known only immediately upon returning.

The Liberation Through Non-Clinging



The Core Insight

You do not need to attain The Deathless to achieve liberation. True liberation carries through from the most transcendent peak experiences all the way to the most ordinary, mundane aspects of daily life.

Releasing the Asavas (Taints): Liberation is actualized by dropping four specific clingings:

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| 1. Sensual Pleasures: Realizing that happiness tied solely to getting what we want is fragile. | 2. Becoming: Releasing the need to hold a fixed identity or be a 'particular way' to feel okay. |
| 3. Ignorance: Ceasing to mistake things that cause suffering for things that cause happiness. | 4. Views: Letting go of rigid, unyielding opinions about how the world or ourselves must be. |

Final Takeaway: Samadhi and Insight do not teach us how to control the world. They teach us how to rest in a harmonious, disentangled relationship with whatever happens. The shift is from a fragile happiness of having to a profound happiness of allowing.